AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR FORCES

The war that gave birth to the United States of America started as a small-scale encounter between British troops and American colonial militia and ended as a major international conflict. The British initially hoped that American loyalists would carry the main burden of suppressing rebellion, but they were disappointed. The deployment of a substantial British army, including mercenary forces from Hessen and other German states, failed to impose a decisive defeat upon the American Continental Army, which instead scored a notable victory at Saratoga in 1777. In the vast spaces of North America, the British could not bring their superior formal fighting skills to bear. In the end the intervention of the French army and navy tipped the balance decisively against Britain.

THE CONTINENTAL ARMY

The decision of the Continental Congress, the government set up by the 13 rebel American colonies, to form an army on 14 June 1775 was based on the belief that only a regular army, rather than a citizens' militia, could beat the British Redcoats. George Washington, the army's commander, had a low opinion of militias and aspired to create a disciplined European-style force, trained to fire musket volleys and advance in formation with bayonets fixed.

From the outset, the Continental Army ran into difficulties. The only troops initially available were New England militiamen, who signed on as short-term regulars, and undisciplined rifleman volunteers from the backwoods. At the start of 1776 even this rag-tag army threatened to disintegrate, because once they had served their term most of the militia went home, having farms and businesses to attend to. It was not until 1777 that a serious effort was made to raise a permanent national army, recruited on a quota basis from all 13 states, with men committed either to a three-year term of service or for the duration of the war. Bounty payments were offered to attract volunteers – initially $20 but rising sharply over time as recruits proved increasingly reluctant to come forward. Inevitably, quotas were filled from the lowest levels of society. Vagrants and criminals found themselves pressed into service, along with British and Hessian deserters and prisoners of war. Despite initial opposition from Washington, slave and free African Americans were allowed to enter the ranks. The states never managed to supply men in sufficient numbers, although some of the shortfall was made up by the conscription of state militiamen to serve one-year terms under Continental command.

It was probably just as well that the numbers of recruits always fell below planned levels, for it proved impossible for the fledgling republic to pay, feed, or clothe them adequately. Although some men were kitted out in uniforms by their state of origin, after a while on campaign many soldiers lacked



Uniform of 4th Maryland Independent Company
This was one of seven companies of 100 men authorized by the state of Maryland in January 1776. Later that year the men, armed with muskets and bayonets, marched north to join the Continental Army in the defence of New York.